speed it had in the original splattering process, but each would now move in the opposite direction. The drops of yolk would fly back into a globule just as scores of little shell pieces arrived on the outskirts, perfectly aligned to fuse together into a smooth ovoid container. The air and floor vibrations would precisely conspire with the motion of the myriad coalescing yolk drops and shell pieces to give the newly re-formed egg just the right kick to jump off the floor in one piece, rise up to the kitchen counter, and land gently on the edge with just enough rotational motion to roll a few inches and gracefully come to rest. This *is* what would happen if we could perform the task of total and exact velocity reversal of everything involved.[3]

Thus, whether an event is simple, like a tennis ball arcing, or something more complex, like an egg splattering, the laws of physics show that what happens in one temporal direction can, at least in principle, also happen in reverse.

Principle and Practice

The stories of the tennis ball and the egg do more than illustrate the time-reversal symmetry of nature's laws. They also suggest why, in the real world of experience, we see many things happen one way but never in reverse. To get the tennis ball to retrace its path was not that hard. We grabbed it and sent it off with the same speed but in the opposite direction. That's it. But to get all the chaotic detritus of the egg to retrace its path would be monumentally more difficult. We'd need to grab every bit of splatter, and simultaneously send each off at the same speed but in the opposite direction. Clearly, that's beyond what we (or even all the King's horses and all the King's men) can really do.

Have we found the answer we've been looking for? Is the reason why eggs splatter but don't unsplatter, even though both actions are allowed by the laws of physics, a matter of what is and isn't practical? Is the answer simply that it's easy to make an egg splatter—roll it off a counter—but extraordinarily difficult to make it unsplatter?

Well, if it were the answer, trust me, I wouldn't have made it into such a big deal. The issue of ease versus difficulty *is* an essential part of the